



And so it was that the ministry issued an order for the IIT teaching staff salary structure, where he had to agree to be "flexible on certain issues" like promotions and appointments. Sibal blames much of the confusion on the media. "People on the beat are not necessarily completely familiar with the system. In the electronic media, you have to give only one byte."

Certainly, with the pace he has set for himself, always on call and working 10-hour days, he believes he has started the process of change in which the abolition of the Class X CBSE examination is one small thing. But

"Either I keep quiet or the media sends people who are a little more familiar with this subject."

"On education, each one of the 1.1 billion in India has an opinion. Education will result in an enthusiastic public debate."

"The education system cannot be changed in 100 days. Harvard was set up in 1636 and MIT in 1861."

"The media thinks if I take a decision, it will be implemented tomorrow."

typically, no sooner does he articulate his vision for a new school curriculum, putting in place a comprehensive continuous evaluation, and of private-public partnership in schools, that he comes up with a brand-new plan—to make the CBSE an international system. "If we can provide quality education at home, why can't we provide it outside?" He sees his role as a harbinger of change. "You need to energise the system with ideas." Which he has in plenty with roundtables on three subjects so far: higher education, school education, and vocational education. It's where stakeholders talk, the minister listens, and the bureaucrats take notes. They don't always finesse the ideas though, the result being decisions that often end up being recalled or altered. Even fabulous ideas need follow through. As Delhi University educationist Anita Rampal points out, there has to be a more considered opinion grounded in the national legacy of equity and social cohesion. "One has to differentiate between a market-driven quick fix solution and a long-run vision."

Sibal insists he has no ideology but he has his critics who insist he is pro-privatisation. Take Vijender Sharma, former president of the Delhi University Teachers' Association, who says the minister is only interested in the commercialisation of education, whether it is through private-public partnerships in schools or through the UGC's letter to universities raising the fees by up to 20 per cent. Sibal has his defenders. Arun Kapur, director, Vasant Valley School, who is on his roundtable on school education, says it is not the minister's job to worry about the details. "You can't blame him if the CBSE replaces his proposal of abolition of the Class X board exam with four exams through Class IX and X. The problem is that the bureaucracy cannot cope with the speed of change."

He has been busy, no doubt, getting The Right of Children to Free and Compulsory Education Bill passed, developing legislations on educational malpractices and on the National Commission for Higher Education, and redrafting the Foreign